



THE SOCIAL WORLD OF A NORTH INDIAN MERCHANT IN MUGHAL TIMES

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THE SOCIAL WORLD OF A NORTH INDIAN MERCHANT IN MUGHAL TIMES

Kalpana Malik

The *Ardhakathanak* of Banarasidas, written in Braj in vs 1696 (AD 1696) tells us much about social life of merchants in Mughal times. First of all, the family seems to have played a very important role. In the life of the author's father Kharagsen, family obligation had played a crucial role. The first such instance comes to life in the person of Madan Singh. Madan Singh Srimal was the elder brother of Kharagsen's maternal grandfather, Chhajmal. After Muldas's death and the consequent confiscation of his property by his employer, his wife (Banarasidas's grandmother) and son (Banarasidas's father) left Narwar and went to Jaunpur, where Madan Singh resided. They travelled under great privation. It was Madan Singh who consoled his niece (Kharagsen's mother) and grandson (Kharagsen) by extending emotional support. He not only fulfilled the obligation of providing them food and clothes but also made available the comfort of their own house.¹ Kharagsen's childhood passed amidst the loving care and warmth of Madan Singh who also shouldered the obligation of educating him.

The second instance of family obligation comes when Kharagsen started his career as businessman. He decided to take the help of his paternal uncle, Sundardas. The two worked in partnership and their mutual love and affection made people refer to them as father and son.² Just as Sundardas had fulfilled his family obligation to set up his nephew in business, Kharagsen reciprocated in the same vein. He too fulfilled the moral duty, which required him as a cousin to get the only daughter of his paternal uncle married.

The author himself availed of kinship ties to secure shelter and food. When Banarasidas reached Agra on his first business venture there, it was raining and he wondered where to go and stay..³ Finally he decided to visit Bandidas, the husband of his younger sister. There is yet another occasion in the author's life when family ties led to the fulfillment of financial obligations. Banarasidas's first business having failed, he received help from his father-in-law's brother Tarachand Tambi. While taking care not to hurt the self-respect of Banarasidas, Tarachand tricked him to visit his house for lunch while he sent someone to pay the rent of Banarasidas's room and also got his meagre belongings fetched to his own house. When all this was accomplished, he implored Banarasidas to stay at his house and the latter had to comply.

The *Ardhakathanak* provides illustrations of how family relationships worked in co-operation to put limits to the waywardness of its members and exercised a moral control. For instance, when Banarasidas went to fetch his wife after marriage, his parents-in-law made an effort to show him the right way and refused to send their daughter with him,⁴ the reason being that his affair with a

courtesan had resulted in his being affected with syphilis and he had become so unsightly that his father in-law and brother in-law refused to sit with him at meals. He was able to recover with the treatment provided by a barber and was attended by his wife and mother in-law. When Kharagesen came to know about it he was utterly ashamed (*lajjit*) of his son and abused him. Banarasidas was filled with great remorse, and cried a lot.⁵ For a while Banarasidas felt completely dejected and disgusted with himself.⁶ But soon he returned to his old ways. After all family pressure does not always work. But it was a humbling experience for Banarasidas and after sometime he again went to fetch his wife. This time he was fortunate and his wife's parents allowed her to accompany him. Banarasidas's parents and elders firmly admonished him.⁷ They asked him to give up his obsession for studies as well as his crazy love affair, so that he could pursue his occupation of a *bania*. In yet another incident related to Dharamdas the family tried to check the bad company and odious habits of one of its members. Dharamdas was considered a bad sheep in the family, while his two brothers Jasu and Amarsi were prosperous merchants.⁸ They nurtured a hope that their brother would also behave in a more responsible manner. Considering this they financed the partnership of Dharamdas with Banarasidas and the two worked hard and succeeded in building up a modest trade.

The *Ardhakathnak* also provides us with an example of how kinship network fulfilled the obligation of arbitration. For settling the partnership accounts with *sahu* Sabal Singh, Banarasidas had to seek the help of Anga Sah, who was a brother in-law of the *sahu*. After waiting in vain for a long time to seek Sabal Singh's attention, Banarasidas luckily met Anga Sah and requested him to plead his case with the *sahu*. Anga Sah finally succeeded in getting his accounts cleared.

From among the women who figure in the *Ardhakathanak*, Banarasidas's grandmother and first wife emerge as strong characters who played decisive roles in his life and career. After her husband's (Muldas's) death, the decision to go to Jaunpur was taken by Kharagsen's mother (the grandmother of Banarasidas). It was here that Kharagsen got his initial training in business. She always motivated her son and gave him permission to go to Bengal to join Rai Dhanā's service. She also gave him some money for travel expenses, yet at the same time, kept the whole matter a secret from her uncle Madan Singh.⁹ Perhaps she thought that it would be good if her son started earning on his own and relieve her uncle who was shouldering their financial responsibility.

In the case of the author, it was his wife who fulfilled the popular saying that behind the success of every man lies the hand of a woman. When Banarasidas's first business venture failed, his wife consoled him by saying that he ought not to worry and considered that as long as a man was alive, he could always achieve everything.¹⁰ Her role became important in influencing the course of Banarasidas's life, for it was she who put his business life back on the track. It

was she who suggested to Banarasidas that instead of going to Jaunpur, he should go to Agra, and with the help of her mother, she even financed her husband's investments. However, both the ladies were careful enough not to reveal this gesture of help.¹¹

During his second visit to Agra he came into contact with Tarachand Mothiya who set him up with Narottamdas to go to Patna for business. It later resulted in a useful partnership and Banarasidas finally succeeded as a businessman. The unstinted support of Banarasidas's wife helped him to overcome a very difficult phase in his life. This was the reason that when the author received the news of his wife's death, after she had delivered a third son (both the wife and son died after fifteen days), it came as a tragic blow and he burst into tears.¹² Though Banarasidas's grandmother and first wife carved an identity of their own as strong women who played crucial roles, as is evident from the discussion above, it is surprising that the author does not mention their names. They are introduced to us just through their relation to the author and his father.

The *Ardhakathanak* tells us that education and training were important prerequisites for the success of a businessman. The author's grandfather was proficient in both Hindi and Persian languages.¹³ This linguistic skill helped him to conduct a profitable business in money-lending. Hindi was his mother-tongue but to have the knowledge of Persian, meant an added advantage after it was made the sole language of state business by Raja Todarmal.¹⁴ The successful career of a *bania* largely depended on the rigorous training he received from early childhood in subjects such as arithmetic and accountancy which had a direct bearing on his business.¹⁵ This helped a *banya* to make the most intricate calculations in his head and memorize elaborate tables.¹⁶

The author's father, Kharagsen, was sent to school when he was eight years old. With formal education was combined the art of conducting business. He soon learnt to read and write.¹⁷ Later, he acquired the art of testing precious metals.¹⁸ In this way he learnt assaying and money-changing which were crucial to the profession of *sarrafi*. In both his partnerships Kharagsen practised *sarrafi*. Kharagsen also learnt about drafting bills for money-lending and account keeping.¹⁹ After this initial education, he began to frequent the market place to learn how *sarrafi* was actually conducted. Banarasidas himself acquired education at the same age as his father.²⁰ He learnt to read and write accounts.²¹ He studied for a year and his 'wisdom grew day by day'. By 1595 A.D. Banarasidas completed the kind of education required for doing business. This education and training helped him to maintain proper ledgers of account. This he specifically mentions in connection with his first partnership with Dharamdas.²²

Kharagsen's proper and timely initiation into business by his maternal grandfather Madan Singh, boosted his confidence, and he ventured to travel to

Bengal at the young age of twelve years and got himself employed as the *fotadar* (treasurer) of Rai Dhana. At eighteen years he started his first partnership. In the case of Banarasidas, though his father Kharagsen provided good education to him and even tried to interest him in business, Banarasidas initially did not show much inclination. This gets reflected through the first few failures which he experienced in business. It was most probably the result of the lack of practical training which the author did not take care of.

Usually, caste is not recognized in Jainism. Therefore, the existence of caste system is considered a social and not a religious institution and attributed to Hindu influence.²³ But in the *Ardhakathanak*, we come across different castes such as Srimals, Oswals, Agarwals and Maheshwari. Out of these the first three are among the dominant Jain castes. Russell and Lall have classified the main sub-castes as coming from Rajputana, Bundelkhand and the United Provinces. Among the others, the Srimals, Oswals, and Maheshwari were among the leading Rajputana groups. The Agarwals came from the United Provinces.²⁴ Most of the Agarwals were Vaishnavas but some were Jains as well.

Banarasidas mentions as many as nine septs (*gotras*) of Srimals which included - Biholia, Badaliya, Chhinaliya, Dhor, Khobra, Kukdi, Mothiya, Singhad and Tambi. His relatives and friends belonged to most of these *gotras*. With Narottamdas of Khobra *gotra* and the Mothiya household Banarasidas did business in partnership. Banarasidas and his father also worked in partnership outside their caste. Kharagsen worked with Ramdas Agarwal and Banarasidas with Dharamdas of the Oswal caste.²⁵ Ramdas did not belong to the Jain community and was a worshipper of Shiva.²⁶ Our argument in the present work has been that business was conducted in partnership not only within the caste but even outside the caste.

The text informs us that there was co-operation among the *banias* belonging to different castes. This notion gets highlighted through the hospitality extended to Kharagsen by Karamchand Mahur.²⁷ A political persecution compelled the former to leave his native place Jaunpur and he fled to Shahzadpur along with his family. The author informs us about Karamchand that he was a *bania* by profession and vacated his own house to lodge Kharagsen and his family. This proves that they had a very cordial relationship, though the author remains silent about their past association. In the coming days, Karamchand and Kharagsen became 'good friends' and remained together 'day and night'. In this way Kharagsen resided at Shahzadpur for ten months. The very fact that both were merchants denoted that they could not have spent this time idly together, doing nothing. But we do not have any information whether the two of them entered into partnership or carried out some trade.

Banarasidas's ancestors were Rajputs who later got converted to Jainism at the behest of a guru. Ahimsa, one of the main principles of Jainism, lays great

emphasis on avoiding destruction of living beings. Since agriculture and the profession of warriors cause destruction of life, it led to the majority of Jains to take up business in this community. It was in the same spirit that the author's ancestors being Rajputs gave up the profession of.²⁸

The author himself had varied religious experiences. From a worshipper of Shiva, for sometime Banarasidas became a strict Jain, observing all the rituals, vows and fasts. This was also the time when Banarasidas offered worship at a Jain shrine along with two friends requesting the deity to grant him wealth. Later at thirty-five years of age he became an *Adhyatmi* - a sect of Jainism, that shunned ritual practices. The author was introduced to Adhyatma by Arathmal Dhor, when he went to Khairabad to get married for the third time. He felt a transformation taking place within himself.²⁹ His faith in rituals and all outward forms of religion stated shaking. He also gave up the various religious observations which he had earlier undertaken. Banarasidas started mocking at religion along with his friends - Chandarbhan, Udaykaran and Than, which earned him a bad reputation in Agra. It was finally with the help of Pandit Rupchand that Banarasidas's doubts were cleared and he gained true knowledge.³⁰ It was due to the influence of Adyhatma that led the author to confess that he did not observe any penance and abstinence and that he did not like charities and worship.³¹

The medieval European economic world seems to have been somewhat influenced by religion that laid emphasis on moral scruples which to some extent hampered the progress of trade. In the *Ardhkathnak* religion does not seem to overshadow the business community. In his discussion of the influence of religion on economic behaviour, Bayly thinks that the vows undertaken by merchants to limit worldly possessions 'impinged on the life of men in the bazaars', and he made the following remark: "The wise merchant like Kharagsen makes a vow of restrain from the building of another house".³²

Bayly's notion that religion impinged on mercantile behaviour is slightly misplaced because it was not Kharagsen but Rai Dhana, the *diwan* of Lodi Khan, who undertook the vow of not building another house.³³ Clearly, the entire argument does not hold water. The *Ardhakathanak* does not show that religion motivated the author and his father to make any compromise in their business life. As was the custom, both Kharagsen and Banarasidas participated in three *sanghs* in which a large group of people visited a place of pilgrimage.³⁴ It used to be organized by some financially well off people and a prior permission was required from the state. People were invited to participate in these Sanghs. Such participation however, did not influence how, and with whom, the participants conducted their business.

NOTES AND REFERENCES

- ¹ Banarasidas, *Ardhkathanak*, Lath, *Half a Tale*, verse 67, p. 229.
- ² *Ibid.*, verse 69, p. 229.
- ³ *Ibid.*, verse 311, p. 247.
- ⁴ *Ibid.*, verse 193, p. 238.
- ⁵ *Ibid.*, verse 195, p. 238.
- ⁶ *Ibid.*, verse 197, p. 239.
- ⁷ *Ibid.*, verse 200, p. 239.
- ⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 51.
- ⁹ *Ibid.*, verses 52, 53, p. 227.
- ¹⁰ *Ibid.*, verse 376, p. 252.
- ¹¹ *Ibid.*, verse 384, p. 252.
- ¹² *Ibid.*, verse 444, p. 257.
- ¹³ *Ibid.*, verse 13, p. 224.
- ¹⁴ R.C. Sharma tr. 'The Ardh-Kathanak : A Neglected Source of Mughal History', (hereafter, 'A Neglected Source'), *Indica*, Vol. 7, Nos. 1 and 2, March & September 1970, p. 52.
- ¹⁵ Irfan Habib, 'Merchant Communities in precolonial India', in *The Rise of Merchant Empires, Long Distance Trade in the Early Modern World 1350-1750*, (ed.) James D. Tracy, Cambridge, 1990, p. 383.
- ¹⁶ R. V. Russell and Rai Bahadur Hira Lal, 'Bania', in *Tribes and Castes of the Central Provinces of India*, Vol. IV, Delhi, 1975, p. 128.
- ¹⁷ Banarasidas, *Ardhkathanak*, Lath, *Half a Tale*, verse 46, p. 227.
- ¹⁸ *Ibid.*, verse 46, p. 227.
- ¹⁹ *Ibid.*
- ²⁰ *Ibid.*, verse 98, p. 231.
- ²¹ *Ibid.*
- ²² *Ibid.*, verse 356, p. 250.
- ²³ Vilas Adinath Sangave, *Jain Religion and Community*, Mumbai, 1997, p. 68.
- ²⁴ Russell and Lal, 'Bania', pp. 119, 120.
- ²⁵ Banarasidas, *Ardhkathanak*, Lath (ed.) & tr. *Half a Tale*, verse 352, p. 250.
- ²⁶ *Ibid.*, verse 75, p. 229.
- ²⁷ Nathuram Premi (ed.) *Kavivar Banarasidas-virachit Ardh Kathanak*, Bombay, 1957, glossary, p. 149, Mahur = Mathur, Mahaur, a caste of the Vaishyas.
- ²⁸ Banarasidas, *Ardhkathanak*, Lath, *Half a Tale*, verse 9, p. 224.
- ²⁹ *Ibid.*, verse 596, p. 269.
- ³⁰ *Ibid.*, verse 635, p. 272.
- ³¹ *Ibid.*, verse 653, p. 274.
- ³² Bayly, *Rulers, Townsmen and Bazaars*, Cambridge, 1983, p. 385.
- ³³ Banarasidas, *Ardhkathanak*, Lath (ed.) & tr. *Half a Tale*, verse 51, p. 227.
- ³⁴ Kharagsen participated in the *sanghs* of *diwan* Rai Dhana and Hiranand Mukim while Banarasidas participated in the one organized by Vardhman Kunwarji.